

NorthQuay Retail Group - visual automation brief

Client: NorthQuay Retail Group (fictional, created for this course) Estate: 41 stores in one market, plus one online catalogue Requested by: six departments, independently, within the same quarter

What has happened

Six departments have each asked the technology team for "AI images". None of the six requests arrived with a volume figure, a turnaround requirement or a review owner. Your job is to establish which of them actually need a vision system, and to specify the pipeline for the ones that do.

Hard constraints

These are not preferences. A proposal that breaches any of them is rejected without further review.

1. Cost ceiling - S\$1.20 per delivered asset, all-in, including review time.

Anything above this is cheaper to keep doing by hand at current wage rates.

2. Turnaround - 48 hours maximum from request to delivered asset for catalogue work; 4 hours for social response work. Nothing in this programme is real-time.

3. Customer-image privacy - no image containing an identifiable customer may

leave the store network, be used as training or conditioning input, or be stored outside the in-market environment. Colleague images require written consent held by HR and are still restricted to the in-market environment.

Deliverables

1. A completed needs-analysis scoring matrix covering all six candidate cases.
2. A one-sentence rejection rationale for every case you do not take forward, naming the criterion and the number that caused it.
3. A five-stage pipeline specification for each case you do take forward:

SENSE, REPRESENT, ANALYSE, DECIDE, ACT/SYNTHESISE - with a named measurement at ANALYSE and a numeric threshold at DECIDE.

What "need" means here

A vision system is needed where the task is visual, repeated at volume, consistent enough to specify, and currently expensive. A task that fails any one of those is usually better served by a template, a stock library, or by leaving it alone.

Gate-check warning

The two highest-scoring cases still exceed S\$1.20 per asset (NQ-01: $2600/1450 = S\$1.793$; NQ-02: $1900/820 = S\$2.317$). Their score is not approval. Record HOLD/REJECT and seek a revised evidenced cost before proposing delivery. Missing turnaround/processing evidence stays UNKNOWN.